Q&A

When you started working on rebranding The Public, what was your process for conceiving it, and how did you balance what the institution wanted to be with where it was in its history at that moment?

It was a radical departure. George Wolfe did not directly follow Joe Papp. There was JoAnne Akalaitis in between and she had continued some of what Papp's approach was to advertising. George wanted to make a complete departure to develop his own view of what the theatre should be, otherwise he would always look like a weaker version of Papp. So, the notion was to make it visible in New York City, to be inclusive of everyone, to be loud and proud and take the city by storm, and that's what we did.

It was typographic. The style of the posters in the first couple of seasons were pretty powerful. They were designed from the plays as much as the identities, so there was a real crossover. I don't do that anymore. Now, we do a season and the plays all have a look for the season, even if it's Hamilton. In the beginning we used to really design for each individual play very specifically and in those days they actually printed the posters and they bought newspaper advertisement where you could see the image, so it was more like a Broadway theatre.

That wasn't really effective for The Public, and now I advise the theatre groups against it because what happens is if one play's a hit, you remember the play, but you don't remember the theatre. If the play isn't a hit, you don't remember the play or the theatre. You just know that one image you saw and you don't know where it's from, and that's really bad for these group theatres. People don't have enough money collectively to really support one individual play. If it gets a lot of press, it'll be supported by itself. It's a tricky thing. But when you do a season, it's actually very visible because you're seeing it continually, so you recognize the place.



Paula Scher - Bring in 'da Noise / Bring in 'da Funk